

THE DHĀRMIC THEORY OF
HUMAN FLOURISHING
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• WORKING PAPER I •
**HUMAN FLOURISHING AND
DEMOCRATIC RESILIENCE IN AFRICA:**
A Dhārmic Inquiry



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¹ The Padma Bhushan is one of India's most exalted civilian honours, conferred by the Government of India in recognition of distinguished service of a high order.

Abstract

Democracy in Africa presents a striking contemporary paradox: across much of the continent, citizens continue to express a strong preference for democratic government, even as democratic institutions in several countries experience constitutional manipulation, executive overreach, suppression of political opposition, and declining civic space. The persistence of democratic aspiration alongside institutional erosion raises a question that cannot be answered by electoral design alone: what enables democratic societies to sustain the restraint, legitimacy, and civic responsibility upon which constitutional government depends?

This paper approaches that question through *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing* (DTHF), developed by Nāṭyaśāstra Gurukulam. The theory proposes that flourishing is not merely an outcome to be measured through economic or social indicators, but a generative process rooted in the progressive cultivation of human beings, relationships, institutions, and civilisation according to *Dharma*. Its four generative pillars, namely *Dharma*, the *Triguṇas*, the *Puruṣārthas*, and *Bhakti*, together with the aesthetic pedagogy of *Rasa*, provide a framework for examining how ethical orientation, psychological discipline, ordered material aspiration, and relational participation contribute to the formation of persons and institutions capable of sustaining legitimate public order.

Africa provides a vital context for this inquiry, containing remarkable democratic achievements alongside serious instances of democratic erosion. Rather than prescribing an imported model or portraying African societies through a deficit lens, the paper treats Africa as a comparative field through which the explanatory propositions of DTHF can be examined and refined. Through comparative analysis of South Africa (Nelson Mandela), Botswana, Ghana, Mauritius, Rwanda, and Zimbabwe, it argues that democratic resilience is best understood through the interaction of internal human formation and external institutional restraint. Democracy is not sustained by elections alone: it requires persons and communities capable of recognising legitimate limits, accepting responsibility, accommodating political difference, and subordinating immediate interest to a larger order. The paper therefore distinguishes democratic resilience from human flourishing, treating

resilience as one institutional expression of flourishing where participation, accountability, peaceful alternation, relational trust, and legitimate limits upon power are sustained. It concludes that durable democratic institutions depend not only upon constitutional design and state capability, but also upon the human, relational, and civilisational capacities through which those institutions are inhabited, reproduced, and renewed.

I. The African Democratic Paradox

Africa's democratic experience presents a striking contemporary paradox. The continent is not witnessing a simple disappearance of democratic aspiration. On the contrary, African citizens continue, in large numbers, to prefer democracy over alternative forms of government. Yet democratic institutions in several countries show signs of severe erosion, including constitutional manipulation, executive overreach, suppression of political opposition, declining civic space, and, in some cases, renewed military intervention.

A recent Financial Times editorial captures this tension through examples from Zimbabwe, Tanzania, Uganda, and the Democratic Republic of Congo.² It notes the return of coups, the manipulation of constitutional processes, and the weakening of external pressure for democratic governance. At the same time, Afrobarometer's 2024 survey across thirty-nine African countries found that 66 per cent of respondents preferred democracy to any other form of government, while 80 per cent rejected one-man rule and 78 per cent rejected one-party rule.³

The paradox is therefore precise: democratic aspiration remains stronger than democratic performance. Although two-thirds of respondents preferred democracy, fewer than half described their countries as full democracies or democracies with only minor problems, and only 37 per cent expressed satisfaction with the way democracy was working. Moreover, 53 per cent said they would be willing to accept military intervention if elected leaders abused power for their own ends.⁴

This last finding is significant because it suggests that dissatisfaction with democratic performance may be closely connected to expectations of accountable and restrained government. Citizens may continue to prefer democratic rule while becoming willing to contemplate alternatives when elected institutions fail to constrain the abuse of power. The distinction shifts the analytical question from how to consolidate democratic transitions to what enables democratic institutions to remain legitimate and resilient once established.

² "The Shrinking Space for Democracy in Africa," *Financial Times*, August 6, 2026.

³ Afrobarometer, *African Insights 2024: Democracy at Risk—The People's Perspective* (Accra: Afrobarometer, 2024).

⁴ Ibid.

The central proposition of this paper is that democratic resilience is not solely a problem of institutional design. It is also a problem of human formation: institutions must be inhabited by persons and communities capable of recognising legitimate limits, accepting responsibility, sustaining relationships across political difference, and reproducing these dispositions through civic and institutional life.

Democratic resilience therefore concerns more than the survival of formal institutions. It concerns the capacity of political institutions and political communities to withstand recurring temptations: concentration of power, patronage, factionalism, personalisation of authority, economic capture, political revenge, and the refusal to accept legitimate limits. This raises a deeper question: what enables individuals and institutions to sustain restraint when power creates incentives to evade it?

II. Democratic Institutions and Democratic Resilience

The distinction between democratic aspiration and performance challenges the view that institutional design, by itself, is sufficient to generate durable democratic resilience. Institutions matter profoundly, but they do not act independently of the persons and social relationships that inhabit them. A constitutional order is ultimately exercised by human beings.⁵

This does not mean that human formation substitutes for institutional constraint. On the contrary, the argument of this paper is that durable democratic resilience requires both external and internal restraint. External institutions constrain the exercise of power; internal dispositions make the acceptance of legitimate constraint possible. The two are therefore complementary rather than alternative mechanisms.

The earlier *Good Governance for Growth in Africa* Working Paper argued that Africa's developmental challenge cannot be reduced to a binary choice between Western neoliberalism and centralised state capitalism.⁶ It proposed a framework combining

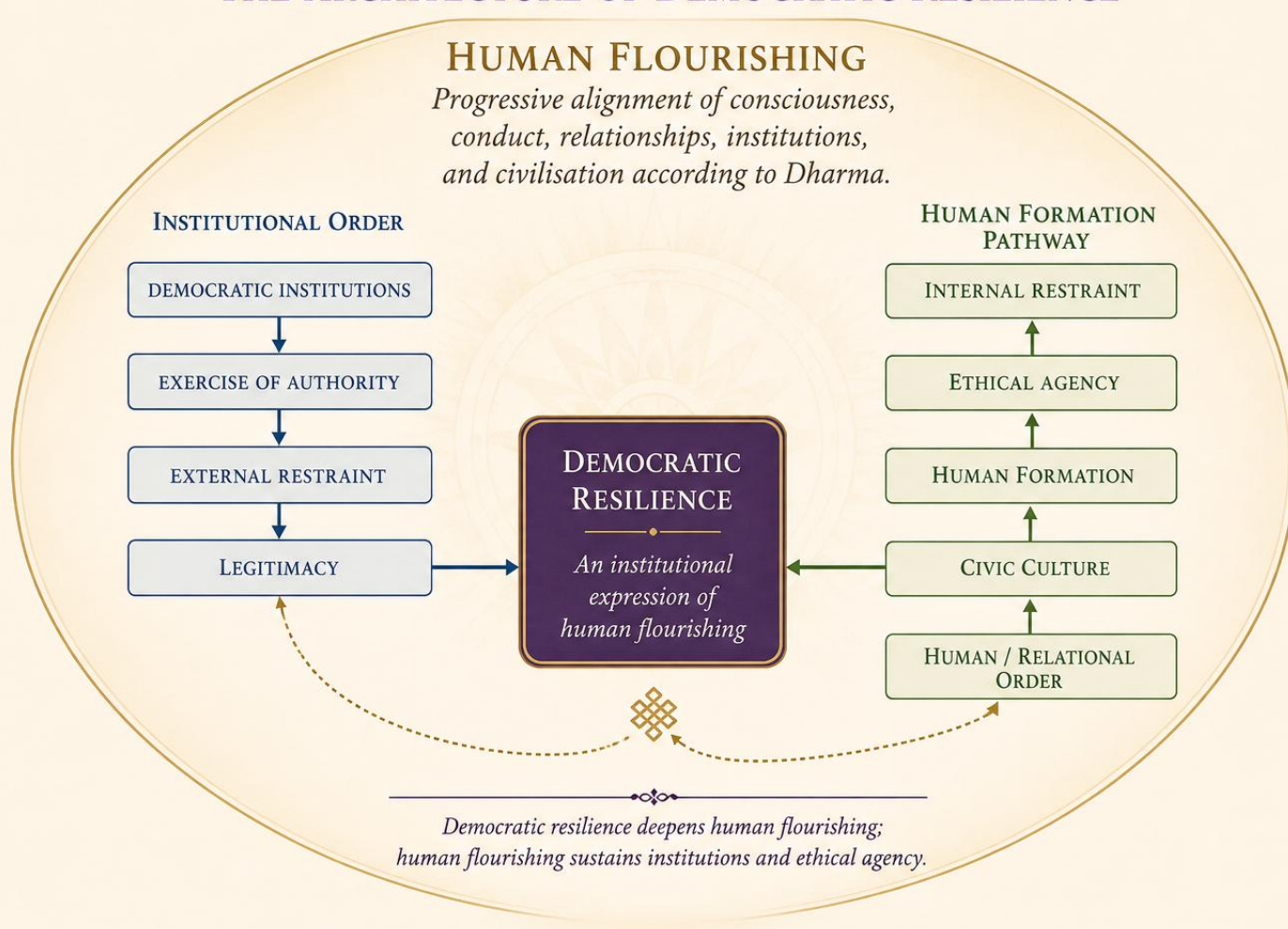
⁵ Rohit Viswanath, [The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing](#), Flagship Treatise, (Navi Mumbai: Nāṭyaśāstra Gurukulam, Civilisational Statecraft Series, 2026), sec. 7.2, "The Five Nested Orders of Human Flourishing."

⁶ Rohit Viswanath, [Good Governance for Growth in Africa](#), Working Paper II, Civilisational Statecraft Series (Navi Mumbai: Nāṭyaśāstra Gurukulam, 2026).

decentralised legitimacy, coordinated capability, and disciplined execution, while emphasising that capability without restraint is inherently unstable.⁷ Institutional breakdown frequently begins with behavioural distortions at the apex of power: unchecked ambition, patronage, and the suppression of feedback.

Governance analysis often treats restraint primarily as an external institutional outcome, expressed through constitutions, courts, electoral institutions, and other formal mechanisms of accountability. External restraint is necessary, but insufficient. When powerful actors subordinate institutions, constitutional amendments can legally extend presidential terms and legal frameworks can be used to exclude political opposition.⁸

FIGURE 1
THE ARCHITECTURE OF DEMOCRATIC RESILIENCE



⁷ Ibid.

⁸ “The Shrinking Space for Democracy in Africa,” *Financial Times*, August 6, 2026.

Democratic resilience therefore requires two complementary forms of restraint:

1. External restraint: laws, constitutions, independent judiciaries, electoral institutions, and accountability mechanisms that constrain power through formal and institutional means.

2. Internal restraint: the disposition of those who possess power to recognise and accept legitimate limits upon its exercise.

For purposes of this inquiry, democratic resilience may therefore be understood as the capacity of a political community to correct concentrations of power, absorb conflict, renew legitimacy, preserve meaningful participation, and maintain legitimate limits upon authority without destroying the common order. This definition treats resilience as a quality of an inhabited political order rather than merely the survival of formal democratic institutions.

External restraint can be designed; internal restraint must be formed. Yet neither is sufficient by itself. External institutions can be manipulated when those who control them refuse their normative purpose; internal virtue without institutionalisation can disappear with the individual who embodies it. Durable democratic resilience therefore requires the translation of personal restraint into institutional restraint, and of institutional restraint into civic culture.

This distinction provides the conceptual bridge to *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*.

III. The Missing Dimension: Human Formation

Democratic resilience therefore becomes, in part, a problem of human formation. What forms the ethical orientation, psychological discipline, relational capacity, and sense of legitimate purpose that enable individuals and communities to sustain institutions over time? It is at this point that the DTHF becomes relevant.

DTHF approaches this problem by asking not merely what flourishing looks like, but how flourishing is generated, cultivated, sustained, and transmitted. It defines flourishing as an emergent order generated through the progressive alignment of consciousness, conduct,

relationships, institutions, and civilisation according to *Dharma*.⁹

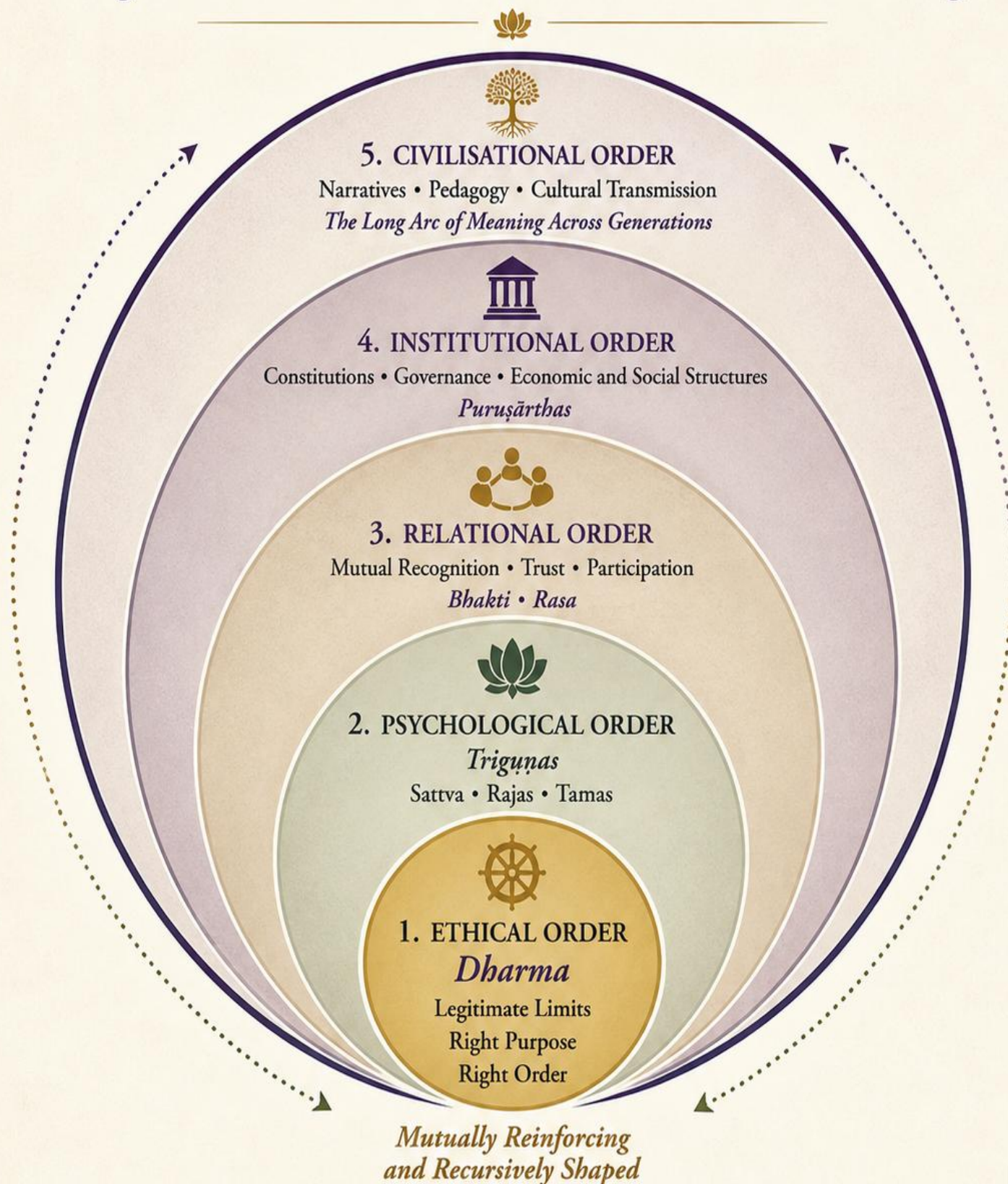
The distinction between generation and embodiment is important. The DTHF's four generative pillars describe the principles through which flourishing is cultivated, while its five nested orders describe the levels of human and collective life across which those principles are embodied, sustained, and transmitted. The four pillars are therefore not additional institutional variables, and the five orders are not independent causal mechanisms; together they constitute an integrated architecture in which human formation and institutional formation are mutually reinforcing.¹⁰

Each pillar illuminates a distinct dimension of human formation relevant to democratic resilience: *Dharma* provides the normative orientation of legitimate limits; the *Triguṇas* address the psychological ordering of agency; the *Puruṣārthas* address the ordering of material and political aspiration; and *Bhakti* provides the relational orientation through which trust, participation, and self-offering may be cultivated. Rasa functions within this relational architecture as an aesthetic pedagogy through which such dispositions may become lived rather than merely procedural. This distinction allows the theory to move from the formation of the person to the resilience of institutions without reducing one to the other.

⁹ Rohit Viswanath, *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*.

¹⁰ Ibid.

Figure 2. The Five Nested Orders of Human Flourishing



Source: Author's conceptual synthesis based on *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*.

Note: The five orders are nested and mutually reinforcing rather than sequential stages. They describe distinct but interdependent dimensions through which flourishing is generated, embodied, sustained, and transmitted; the relationships among them are recursive rather than deterministic.

1. Dharma: The Normative Basis of Legitimate Limits

Dharma is not merely religion or law, but a principle of right order extending from individual consciousness to societal and institutional life. Restraint arises from recognising that power has a proper purpose and scope.¹¹ Political legitimacy therefore cannot be reduced either to procedural validity or to administrative effectiveness; it also concerns whether power continues to be exercised within limits appropriate to its purpose and obligations.¹²

For the present inquiry, *Dharma* therefore provides the normative basis for recognising both the legitimate exercise of power and the legitimate limits upon it.

2. The Trigūṇas: The Psychological Basis of Restraint

To explain why human beings fail to uphold principles they intellectually recognise, DTHF examines the cultivation of consciousness through the *Trigūṇas* (*Sattva, Rajas, and Tamas*). The DTHF does not treat *Rajas* as intrinsically problematic. Political leadership requires energy, ambition, initiative, and the capacity for decisive action. The question is whether such energy is ordered by clarity and legitimate purpose, or becomes attached to possession, domination, and self-preservation. Unrestricted *Rajas* can therefore degenerate into factionalism and domination, while *Rajas* ordered through *Sattva* can become disciplined public action. The relevance to democratic resilience lies not in eliminating political ambition, but in cultivating the capacity to govern it. Democratic resilience requires the ethical ordering of ambition, not its elimination.¹³

3. Bhakti: The Relational Basis of Civic Participation

Rules and logic regulate conduct, but *Bhakti*, understood here as a relational principle of trust, participation, and self-offering, provides a way of examining how formal obligations may become lived civic participation. Within this relational architecture, *Rasa* provides an aesthetic and emotional pedagogy through which persons may encounter histories, identities, differences, and shared aspirations in ways that cultivate recognition and

¹¹ Ibid.

¹² Ibid.

¹³ Ibid.

participation. A resilient democratic culture requires relational formation that enables citizens and political adversaries to regard one another as co-participants in a shared political order.¹⁴

4. The *Puruṣārthas*: Ordering Material and Political Aspiration

The *Puruṣārthas* (*Dharma*, *Artha*, *Kāma*, and *Mokṣa*) form an integrated architecture in which *Dharma* governs the pursuit of material wealth and political power (*Artha*) and educates desire (*Kāma*), while *Mokṣa* provides a horizon of inner freedom. Political authority and economic development are legitimate aspirations, but become destructive when detached from ethical responsibility.¹⁵

The relevance to democratic resilience is that political power and material development are not themselves contrary to flourishing; the question is whether their pursuit remains ordered toward legitimate human and social purposes rather than becoming self-preserving or extractive.

IV. The Five Nested Orders of Human Flourishing

The five orders should be understood as nested rather than sequential. They represent the levels of human and collective life across which the four generative pillars of the DTHF are embodied, sustained, and transmitted. Ethical, psychological, relational, institutional, and civilisational dimensions continuously shape one another. The relationship between person and institution is therefore not linear: institutions form persons even as persons sustain institutions. This recursive character is important to the present inquiry because democratic resilience can be understood both as an expression of human formation and as a context within which human formation continues.

The DTHF synthesises human development into five nested, mutually reinforcing orders:¹⁶

1. **Ethical Order:** Principles defining legitimate political power (*Dharma*) .

¹⁴ Ibid.

¹⁵ Ibid.

¹⁶ Ibid.

2. **Psychological Order:** Dispositions of consciousness enabling self-restraint (*Triguṇas*) .
3. **Relational Order:** Norms enabling competing groups to coexist without existential hostility (*Bhakti/Rasa*) .
4. **Institutional Order:** Embodiment of these dispositions in constitutions, courts, and economic structures (*Puruṣārthas*) .
5. **Civilisational Order:** Shared narratives, educational traditions, and cultural practices reproducing these dispositions across generations .

The orders are therefore not independent layers of social life. Each both shapes and is shaped by the others. Institutional health may become increasingly vulnerable when the underlying ethical, psychological, and relational orders deteriorate; conversely, institutions can reinforce or weaken those orders through the habits and incentives they create. Individual and societal flourishing are consequently mutually constitutive.

V. Methodological Framework and Comparative Case Overview

The application of the DTHF to Africa does not seek to prescribe an imported model or declare African exemplars retrospectively '*Dhārmic*'. Rather, Africa serves as a comparative field of human and institutional experience through which the explanatory propositions of the DTHF can be examined. The cases have been selected because they illuminate different configurations of leadership restraint, institutional continuity, civic expectations, relational accommodation, state capability, and democratic erosion. They are not intended to constitute a statistically representative sample of African states. The comparative purpose is therefore analytical rather than aggregative: the cases are used to illuminate distinct mechanisms and tensions within the proposed theory rather than to establish a continent-wide causal generalisation. Nor are the cases evaluated according to whether they conform to a predetermined *Dhārmic* ideal. Instead, the analysis asks whether the DTHF concepts help illuminate patterns that conventional institutional analysis may not fully capture.

To ensure evaluative rigour across the comparative case studies, the six cases are examined systematically using common analytical dimensions derived from the Five Nested Orders:

ethical, psychological, relational, institutional, and civilisational. These dimensions provide a common vocabulary for comparison while allowing the specific historical and political context of each country to remain visible.

The distinction between evidence and interpretation is maintained throughout. Observable political, institutional, economic, and civic evidence is presented first; DTHF concepts are then used as an interpretive framework rather than treated as directly measurable empirical variables. Terms such as *Dharma*, *Sattva*, *Rajas*, *Tamas*, *Bhakti*, and *Rasa* therefore function as conceptual categories for interpreting patterns of human conduct and collective life, not as quantitative classifications of states or peoples.¹⁷

The resulting comparative case overview is presented below. It brings together the principal observable patterns identified across the six cases and places them in relation to the five nested orders of the DTHF. It is intended as a visual synthesis of the comparative argument, rather than as a quantitative assessment or ranking of countries.

The overview identifies different configurations through which restraint, capability, civic participation, relational accommodation, institutional integrity, and democratic resilience may interact. The four principal cases illustrate different pathways through which restraint may be expressed or embedded: South Africa through leadership restraint, Botswana through institutionalised restraint, Ghana through civic internalisation, and Mauritius through relational accommodation. Rwanda and Zimbabwe serve as counter-cases, illustrating respectively the tension between substantial state capability and insufficient political restraint, and the consequences of the erosion of institutional and internal restraint.

The subsequent case studies examine these configurations in greater depth. They do not assume that the patterns identified in the matrix establish causal relationships. Rather, they ask whether the DTHF provides a useful conceptual vocabulary for understanding why some forms of democratic order endure while others become vulnerable to the concentration, personalisation, or misuse of power.

¹⁷ Viswanath, *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*, sec. 7.1, “Dialogue with Modern Empirical Frameworks.”

Table 1. COMPARATIVE CASE OVERVIEW
Six configurations examined through the Five Nested Orders of DTHF

The six cases illuminate distinct pathways and tensions through which democratic resilience emerges, consolidates, or remains incomplete, when examined through the DTHF.

THE FIVE NESTED ORDERS OF DTHF



DEMOCRATIC RESILIENCE CASES

Four pathways demonstrating restraint, accountability and inclusive legitimacy

 SOUTH AFRICA <i>Leadership Restraint</i>  Personal self-limitation subordinates power to reconciliation and constitutional order. Key Orders Illuminated ✓ Ethical ✓ Psychological ✓ Relational ✓ Institutional	 BOTSWANA <i>Institutionalised Restraint</i>  Long-term incumbency yielded to electoral defeat and peaceful transfer, strengthening constitutionalism. Key Orders Illuminated ✓ Ethical ✓ Institutional ✓ Civilisational	 GHANA <i>Civic Internalisation</i>  Citizen expectations of character and integrity reinforce democratic accountability. Key Orders Illuminated ✓ Psychological ✓ Relational ✓ Institutional	 MAURITIUS <i>Relational Accommodation</i>  Pluralism and accommodation sustain distinct identities within a shared democratic framework. Key Orders Illuminated ✓ Relational ✓ Institutional ✓ Civilisational
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COUNTER-CASES · LIMITS AND EROSION OF DEMOCRATIC RESILIENCE

Two configurations highlighting the conditionality of flourishing

 RWANDA <i>Capability Outruns Restraint</i>  Strong state capability and development coexist with restricted political pluralism, limiting comprehensive flourishing. Key Tension  Institutional capability without adequate pluralism and restraint. Key Orders Illuminated ✓ Institutional ✓ Psychological ✓ Relational (tension)	 ZIMBABWE <i>Erosion of Institutional Restraint</i>  Unchecked power weakens institutions despite persistent democratic aspiration. Key Tension  Erosion of institutional restraint undermines legitimacy and order. Key Orders Illuminated ✓ Ethical ✓ Institutional ✓ Civilisational (tension)
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Comparative Proposition

Democratic resilience is strengthened when restraint is progressively translated from human disposition into civic expectation, relational practice and institutional convention. The counter-cases illuminate what occurs when capability outruns restraint or institutional restraint erodes.

 Democratic Resilience Cases: South Africa · Botswana · Ghana · Mauritius |  Counter-Cases: Rwanda · Zimbabwe

Note: The overview is not intended to rank the countries or assign relative scores of flourishing. It identifies the principal mechanism or tension through which each case contributes to the comparative inquiry developed in the ensuing sections.

VI. Case Study 1: Nelson Mandela and Executive Restraint at the Moment of Power

Nelson Mandela's political leadership provides an illustration of executive self-limitation. Emerging from twenty-seven years of imprisonment into a political environment marked by historical grievance and violence, Mandela assumed office at a moment when the transition could readily have been shaped by retribution and political exclusion. Instead, political liberation was directed toward building a political order in which former adversaries remained members of the same political community.¹⁸

Mandela's significance lies in the transformation of political liberation into an effort at democratic statecraft.¹⁹ Restraint in this context was not weakness, but the capacity to subordinate immediately available power to a larger conception of political order. Read through the DTHF, this can be understood as the subordination of *Artha* (political power) to *Dharma* (right order).

This orientation was reflected in three important choices:

1. **Government of National Unity:** Power-sharing following the 1994 election, bringing former political adversaries into a common governing framework.²⁰
2. **Reconciliation as Relational Order:** Mandela's effort to transform political opponents from existential enemies into participants in a shared political community.²¹
3. **Voluntary Relinquishment of Office:** Stepping down after a single five-year term in 1999, reinforcing the principle that political office is temporary and subordinate to the constitutional order.²²

Mandela's leadership therefore illustrates a potential transmission mechanism: human restraint becomes political practice, political practice becomes institutional convention, and institutional convention contributes to democratic resilience.

¹⁸ Norwegian Nobel Committee, "The Nobel Peace Prize 1993," press release, October 15, 1993.

¹⁹ Nelson Mandela Foundation, "Democracy," accessed August 10, 2026, <https://www.nelsonmandela.org>

²⁰ Nelson Mandela, "1994 Presidential Inauguration Address," Pretoria, May 10, 1994.

²¹ Nelson Mandela, "Nobel Lecture," Oslo, December 10, 1993, NobelPrize.org.

²² Nelson Mandela Foundation, "Biography of Nelson Mandela," accessed August 11, 2026.

The significance for the DTHF is not that Mandela should be labelled '*Dhārmic*', but that his conduct provides an empirical instance through which the theory's proposition concerning the relationship between inner restraint and public order can be examined. The relevant analytical sequence is therefore not 'Mandela was *Dhārmic*', but: *personal restraint* → *political practice* → *institutional convention* → *democratic resilience*.²³

Mandela's significance, however, extends beyond the institutional conventions of his own presidency. His leadership has also entered the civilisational memory of South Africa's democratic transition through public narratives, commemorations, educational practices, and the continuing symbolic remembrance of reconciliation and constitutional restraint. In this sense, an individual example of restraint may become part of the cultural repertoire through which subsequent generations understand legitimate political leadership. The Mandela case therefore illustrates a further dimension of the DTHF architecture: personal restraint can become political practice; political practice can become institutional convention; and institutional convention, through memory and cultural transmission, can contribute to civilisational memory.

VII. Case Study 2: Botswana, When Restraint Becomes Institutionalised

If South Africa demonstrates restraint in leadership, Botswana tests whether restraint can become institutionalised beyond individual figures.

Botswana's long political and developmental trajectory provides an important context for examining the relationship between institutional continuity, state capability, and democratic accountability.²⁴ The Botswana Democratic Party (BDP) governed continuously from independence in 1966 until October 2024. Yet when the opposition Umbrella for Democratic Change (UDC) won the October 2024 election, the BDP conceded defeat and power was transferred peacefully. The African Union specifically commended former President Mokgweetsi Masisi for conceding defeat and facilitating a smooth transfer of

²³ Norwegian Nobel Committee, "Award Ceremony Speech," Oslo, December 10, 1993.

²⁴ World Bank, *Botswana Country Overview* (Washington, DC: World Bank Group, 2025).

power.²⁵

The resilience of Botswana's democratic order, however, cannot be attributed to incumbent restraint alone. The persistence of opposition politics during prolonged BDP dominance kept electoral competition and the possibility of alternation alive. The opposition's ability to sustain a democratic alternative over successive electoral cycles meant that political change remained conceivable within the constitutional order, even when alternation appeared distant. The 2024 transition therefore represented not only the willingness of incumbents to relinquish power, but also the endurance of democratic hope through sustained opposition.

Afrobarometer data provide evidence of strong civic expectations of constitutional restraint in Botswana: 72 per cent prefer democracy, 93 per cent reject one-person rule without accountability to Parliament and elections, 76 per cent believe the president should be accountable to Parliament, and 80 per cent insist that the president obey the laws and courts even when he disagrees with them.²⁶

These findings point to a democratic aspiration that extends beyond periodic elections to expectations concerning the proper limits of executive power. Botswana has also performed comparatively strongly on international measures of democratic quality: the Economist Intelligence Unit's 2024 Democracy Index ranked Botswana 35th globally, ahead of several European, Asian, and Latin American democracies. The significance of Botswana therefore lies not simply in institutional continuity or electoral regularity, but in the combination of comparatively strong democratic performance with substantial citizen expectations of accountability, constitutional limits, and legitimate executive restraint.²⁷

Botswana therefore raises a further question of civilisational integration: whether modern constitutional institutions can coexist with endogenous forms of deliberation and

²⁵ African Union Commission, "AUC Chairperson Commends Credible Elections and Smooth Democratic Transition in Botswana," November 1, 2024.

²⁶ Mogopodi Lekorwe and Wilford Molefe, "AD583: Botswana Insist on Presidential Accountability," *Afrobarometer*, December 15, 2022.

²⁷ Economist Intelligence Unit, *Democracy Index 2024* (London: Economist Intelligence Unit, 2025), 16; Afrobarometer, "AD583: Botswana Insist on Presidential Accountability," December 15, 2022.

traditional authority. This does not establish that traditional institutions are inherently democratic; rather, it illustrates the possibility of institutional adaptation in which inherited forms of public deliberation coexist with constitutional structures. Recent scholarship identifies the *Kgotla*, the traditional village assembly, as a continuing institution of participatory and deliberative political practice in Botswana, linking contemporary democratic culture with indigenous traditions of self-rule, deliberation, and community accountability.²⁸

The advisory role of the *Ntlo ya Dikgosi* (House of Chiefs), which provides traditional representation and advice on matters including tribal affairs, land, and constitutional questions, illustrates one way in which modern constitutionalism can coexist with endogenous institutions.²⁹ Yet the persistence of dissatisfaction with democratic performance and growing concerns about corruption highlight that institutional survival must be accompanied by continuous renewal.³⁰

The DTHF significance of Botswana lies therefore not simply in the existence of stable institutions, but in what happens when those institutions are tested. The decisive moment was not prolonged incumbency itself, but the acceptance of legitimate electoral loss. In this sense, restraint moved from the disposition of political actors into an institutional norm: power could be held for decades, but it could also be peacefully relinquished.

The Botswana case therefore adds a further dimension: democratic resilience requires not only the restraint of those who hold power, but also the persistence of those who seek to replace them through legitimate means. Sustained democratic expectations on both sides of political competition help keep constitutional alternation possible.

²⁸ Bernd Reiter, “Kgotla Democracy Today,” in *The African Origins of Democracy* (Cham: Palgrave Macmillan, 2026), 111–136.

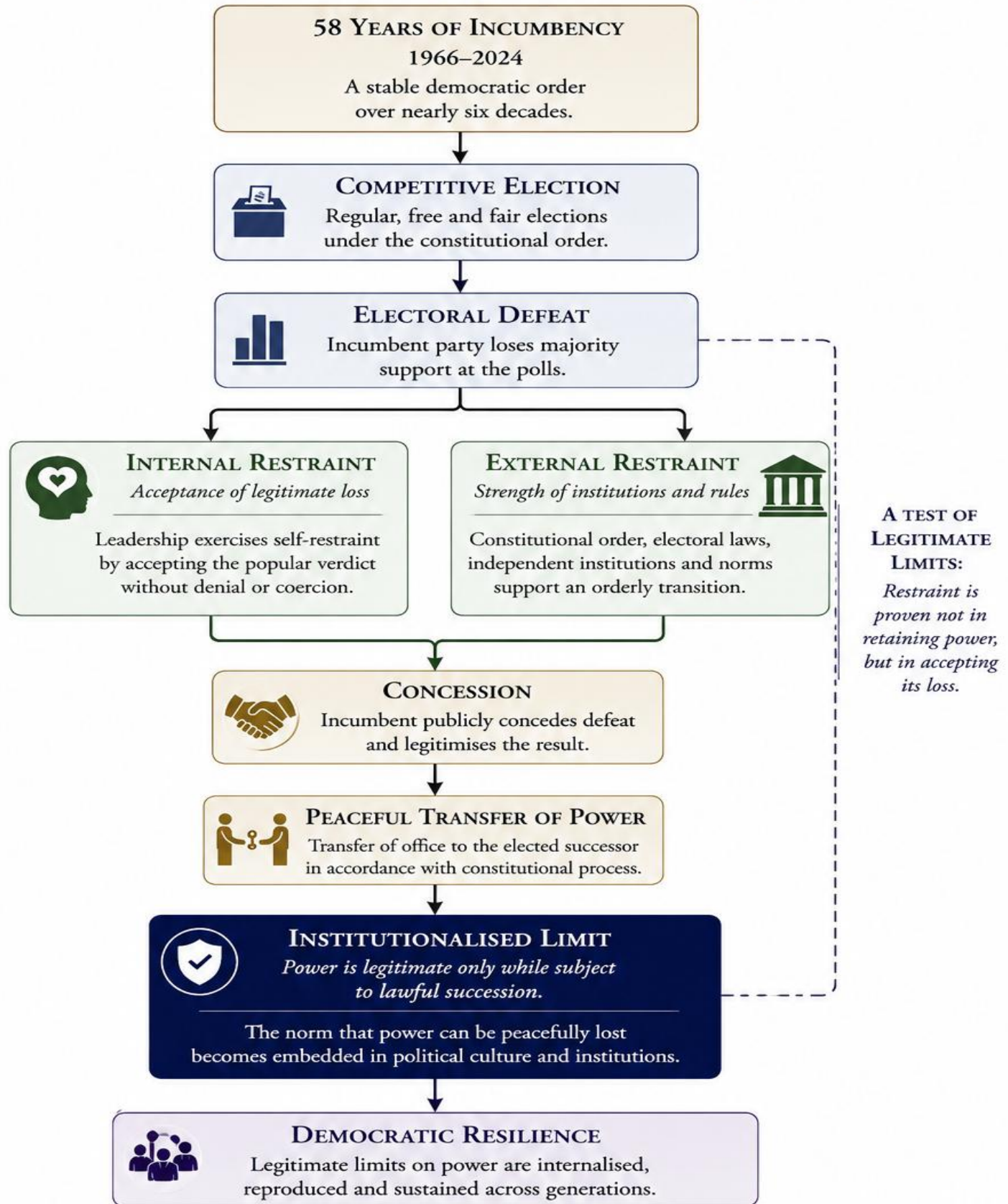
²⁹ Freedom House, “Botswana,” *Freedom in the World* 2026.

³⁰ Batlang Seabo and Wilford Molefe, “AD791: Rising Perceptions of Corruption, Weak Trust, and Low Approval Ratings Mark Botswana Assessments of Their President,” *Afrobarometer*, March 28, 2024.

FIGURE 3

Botswana: When Restraint Becomes Institutionalised

Electoral defeat as a test of legitimate limits upon power



Note: The figure distinguishes observed political events from their interpretation through the DTHF. “Internal restraint” and “institutionalised limit” are analytical interpretations of the observed sequence, not directly measured variables.

Source: Electoral and institutional evidence cited in Section VII; Afrobarometer data cited in the accompanying discussion.

VIII. Case Study 3: Ghana, When Restraint Becomes a Civic Norm

Ghana's Fourth Republic, established in 1992, illustrates how democratic restraint can become embedded in civic expectations and electoral practice. Ghana has achieved repeated peaceful transfers of power between rival parties, the National Democratic Congress (NDC) and the New Patriotic Party (NPP), most recently in December 2024. Afrobarometer has described Ghana as a democracy characterised by regular elections and peaceful transitions of power.³¹

The evidence reveals strong civic expectations concerning democratic choice, political alternation, and the character of political leadership. In the survey reported in 2024, 84 per cent of Ghanaians said elections were the best way to choose their leaders; 69 per cent preferred a system in which power sometimes changes hands between political parties rather than one party governing continuously; and 57 per cent believed that losing parties should accept defeat and cooperate with the elected government.³²

A separate Afrobarometer Round 10 survey conducted in August 2024 adds a particularly revealing dimension concerning the character of political leadership. Ninety per cent of respondents identified a candidate's honesty, 88 per cent the candidate's character, and 59 per cent campaign promises as factors influencing their electoral choices.³³ The ordering is significant: attributes of character were valued substantially above campaign promises.

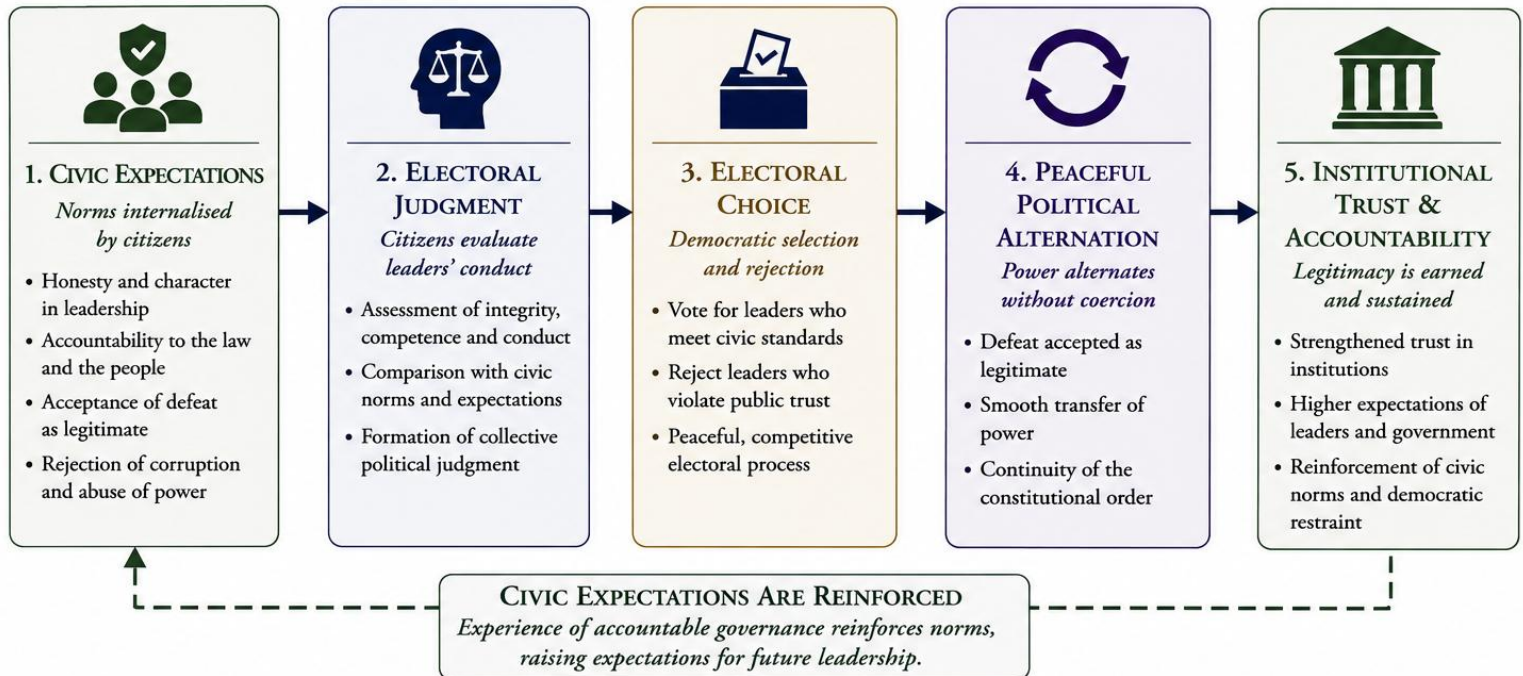
These findings do not establish that civic character directly causes democratic resilience. They do, however, indicate that citizens bring normative expectations concerning honesty, character, accountability, and legitimate political alternation into the electoral process. Ghana therefore provides a useful case for examining how human formation may become civic judgment, and how civic judgment may contribute to democratic accountability.

³¹ David Kofi Asante-Darko, "AD781: Ghanaians Want Fair and Competitive Elections, but Mistrust the Electoral Commission," *Afrobarometer*, March 7, 2024.

³² *Ibid.*

³³ Afrobarometer, "Ghanaians Prioritise Candidate Honesty, Character, and Campaign Promises in 2024 Elections, Afrobarometer Survey Shows," October 25, 2024.

FIGURE 4
From Civic Character to Democratic Alternation: Ghana
A generative pathway of democratic restraint



Note: The figure presents a proposed generative relationship rather than a deterministic causal sequence. Civic expectations may shape electoral judgment and political alternation, while institutional performance in turn reinforces or weakens those expectations.



Source: Afrobarometer, *Summary of Results: Ghana Round 10 Survey* (Accra: Afrobarometer, 2024).

For DTHF, this is significant because it shifts attention from the character of leaders alone to the character expectations held by citizens who select them and, through electoral accountability, influence the exercise of political authority. The relevant movement is therefore: *Civic expectations → electoral judgment → electoral choice → peaceful political alternation → institutional trust and accountability.*

This is the mechanism represented in Figure 4. The relationship should be understood as generative rather than deterministic: civic expectations may shape electoral judgment and political alternation, while institutional performance can in turn reinforce or weaken those expectations.

IX. Case Study 4: Mauritius, Pluralism, Accommodation, and Relational Flourishing

Mauritius addresses the relational dimension of democratic resilience: how a socially, ethnically, and religiously plural society can sustain a democratic order without requiring cultural homogenisation.

Mauritius contains diverse Hindu, Muslim, Creole, Franco-Mauritian, and Sino-Mauritian communities. Since independence, it has held thirteen general elections and maintained a competitive multiparty system with regular transfers of political power. In November 2024, the opposition Alliance for Change won 60 of the 62 directly elected seats in the National Assembly, producing another peaceful transfer of political power.³⁴

Afrobarometer findings reveal strong civic expectations concerning political choice, pluralism, accountability, and the role of the media. Eighty-six per cent of Mauritians support elections as the best way to choose their leaders, while 68 per cent say that many political parties are necessary to ensure voters have a real choice. Sixty-eight per cent also believe that losing parties should accept defeat and cooperate with the government.³⁵ In addition, 78 per cent believe that the prime minister should regularly explain to the National Assembly how the government spends taxpayers' money, while 86 per cent support a media role in investigating and reporting government mistakes and corruption.³⁶

The Mauritian experience provides a useful setting in which the DTHF's relational order (*Bhakti/Rasa*) can be examined: political unity may be sustained through integration rather than enforced homogenisation. The relevant question is not whether social difference disappears, but whether civic and institutional practices enable diverse communities to remain participants in a shared political order.

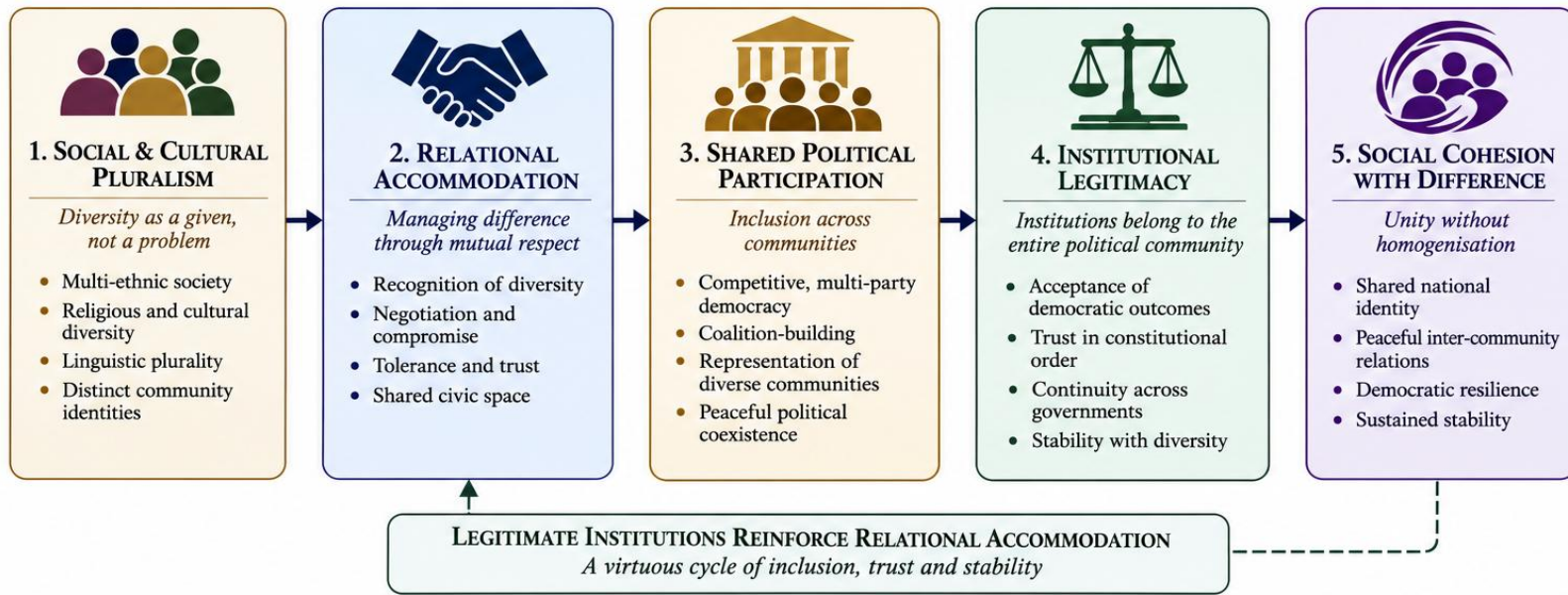
Mauritius therefore allows the DTHF's relational order to be examined in a plural setting.

³⁴ International IDEA, “Mauritius: Opposition Coalition Wins Landslide Victory in Legislative Elections,” *The Global State of Democracy*, November 2024.

³⁵ Asafika Mpako and Stephen Ndoma, “AD873: Ahead of 2024 Polls, Mauritians Value Political Competition, Unsure about Electoral Commission,” *Afrobarometer*, October 4, 2024.

³⁶ Afrobarometer, “Mauritius,” Round 10 country data; Asafika Mpako and Stephen Ndoma, “AD877: Mauritians Approach Election with Diminished Confidence in the Freedom of Their Press,” *Afrobarometer*, October 9, 2024.

FIGURE 5
From Pluralism to Shared Political Participation: Mauritius
Relational accommodation as a mechanism of democratic resilience



THE MAURITIUS LESSON
Deep diversity can coexist with democratic unity when difference is met with accommodation and shared participation.

Note: The figure presents a proposed generative relationship rather than a deterministic causal sequence. Social pluralism does not automatically produce accommodation; the relationship depends upon civic and institutional practices that enable recognition, participation and legitimate political coexistence.

Source: Afrobarometer, *Summary of Results: Mauritius Round 10 Survey* (Port Louis: Afrobarometer, 2024); Freedom House, *Freedom in the World 2026: Mauritius* (Washington, DC: Freedom House, 2026).



Democratic resilience may depend not upon eliminating social difference, but upon developing practices of mutual recognition, participation, trust, accommodation, and shared political belonging. These concepts should be treated as analytical questions rather than as labels imposed upon Mauritian society.

The proposed mechanism is therefore not *diversity* → *legitimacy*, but *pluralism* → *relational accommodation* → *shared political participation* → *institutional legitimacy*, with legitimate institutions in turn reinforcing the conditions for continued accommodation. This is the generative relationship represented in Figure 5.

X. Case Study 5: Counter-Case (i), Rwanda: When Capability Outruns Restraint

Rwanda provides a crucial counter-case for testing whether state capability and developmental success, in the absence of sufficient political restraint and plural accountability, are sufficient for comprehensive human flourishing.

Following the 1994 genocide, the Rwandan Patriotic Front (RPF) built substantial state capacity, public administration, national security, and developmental capability. Rwanda's real GDP grew by 9.4 per cent in 2025, following average growth of 8.5 per cent during 2022–2024.³⁷ Poverty reduction and the inclusiveness of this growth remain important challenges.

However, political space remains tightly controlled. Freedom House classifies Rwanda as 'Not Free', noting severe constraints on political opposition, media, civil society, and political pluralism.³⁸ In the July 2024 presidential election, President Paul Kagame received 99.18 per cent of the vote, according to the National Electoral Commission.³⁹ The electoral field was also restricted. Prominent opposition figures, including Diane Rwigara and Victoire Ingabire, were prevented from contesting the presidency through different legal and institutional barriers.⁴⁰

³⁷ World Bank, "Rwanda," *World Bank Group*, accessed August 11, 2026, reporting that Rwanda's GDP grew by 9.4 percent in 2025, following average growth of 8.5 percent during 2022–2024, and noting continuing challenges concerning poverty reduction, productivity, employment, and the inclusiveness of growth.

³⁸ Freedom House, "Rwanda: Freedom in the World 2026 Country Report," *Freedom in the World 2026*, 2026, classifying Rwanda as "Not Free" with a global freedom score of 21/100 and documenting severe restrictions on political pluralism, opposition participation, media freedom, civil society, and judicial independence.

³⁹ National Electoral Commission of Rwanda, "Provisional Results of Presidential and Legislative Elections," press release, July 18, 2024, reporting that Paul Kagame received 8,822,794 votes, or 99.18 percent of valid votes cast.

⁴⁰ Human Rights Watch, "Rwanda: Respect Rights During Elections," June 14, 2024, documenting the electoral commission's disqualification of Diane Rwigara and the obstacles preventing Victoire Ingabire's party, DALFA-Umurinzi, from registering and participating in the election; see also Freedom House, "Rwanda: Freedom in the World 2025 Country Report," which identifies both Rwigara and Ingabire among prominent opposition figures disqualified from running.

FIGURE 6

Capability without Sufficient Restraint: The Rwanda Counter-Case

Why capability alone yields partial rather than comprehensive flourishing



Note: The figure illustrates a proposed analytical distinction rather than a deterministic causal model. State capability can generate order and developmental capacity, but comprehensive flourishing requires its integration with legitimate restraint, plural accountability, and meaningful participation.



Source: Author's synthesis based on the Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing (DTHF) and the Rwanda case analysis.

In DTHF terms, Rwanda demonstrates substantial administrative capability and organisational discipline, but its political order raises a DTHF question about whether developmental capability is sufficiently balanced by legitimate political self-limitation and plural accountability. Rwanda therefore raises three propositions for the DTHF:

1. Capability is not identical to legitimacy.
2. Order is not identical to freedom or participation.
3. Administrative discipline, unless balanced by legitimate political restraint and avenues for plural accountability, may produce a stable or developmental order without encompassing all the dimensions of human flourishing.

Rwanda is consequently not treated as a 'failed' case. It is better understood as a partial-order case: one that demonstrates substantial achievement in certain dimensions of collective capability and developmental performance while exposing unresolved tensions between capability, political restraint, plural accountability, and participation.

This distinction is central to the DTHF argument. The question is not whether Rwanda has achieved order, capability, or material progress. It demonstrably has. The question is whether these achievements are sufficiently integrated with the ethical, relational, and institutional conditions through which flourishing becomes comprehensive and sustainable. The Rwanda case therefore illustrates what occurs when capability substantially outruns political restraint and plural accountability.

XI. Case Study 6: Counter-Case (ii), Zimbabwe: When Restraint Erodes

Zimbabwe provides the inverse path to Rwanda: rather than capability substantially outrunning restraint, the case illustrates the progressive erosion of both internal and institutional restraints on political power.

Zimbabwe reveals the distinction between democratic aspiration and democratic institutional performance with unusual clarity. Citizens can retain a strong preference for democracy while judging the institutions through which democracy is delivered to be

seriously deficient. The case therefore permits the paper to distinguish between the persistence of democratic aspiration and the erosion of democratic institutional capacity. Afrobarometer’s 2024 findings are particularly significant in this regard: 85 per cent of Zimbabweans preferred democracy to any other form of government, while 88 per cent rejected one-man rule, 72 per cent rejected one-party rule, and 72 per cent rejected military rule.⁴¹

Under ZANU-PF governance since independence in 1980, institutions intended to constrain executive authority have been progressively subordinated to political power. Freedom House assigns Zimbabwe a global freedom score of 25/100 and classifies it as ‘Not Free’, citing severe repression of political opposition and critical media, endemic corruption, a vast patronage system, weak rule of law, and the consolidation of executive authority through constitutional changes.⁴²

The erosion of institutional restraint became particularly visible in the constitutional changes enacted in 2026. Amendments signed into law in July 2026 extended presidential and parliamentary terms from five to seven years, postponed the next presidential election from 2028 to 2030, and replaced direct presidential elections with selection by Parliament. These changes substantially altered the mechanisms through which executive authority is electorally constrained.⁴³

⁴¹ Afrobarometer, “Zimbabweans Prefer Democracy to Any Other Kind of Government, but Many Are Dissatisfied with How Democracy Works in the Country,” news release, September 17, 2024. The release reports that 85 percent prefer democracy, while 88 percent reject one-man rule, 72 percent reject one-party rule, and 72 percent reject military rule.

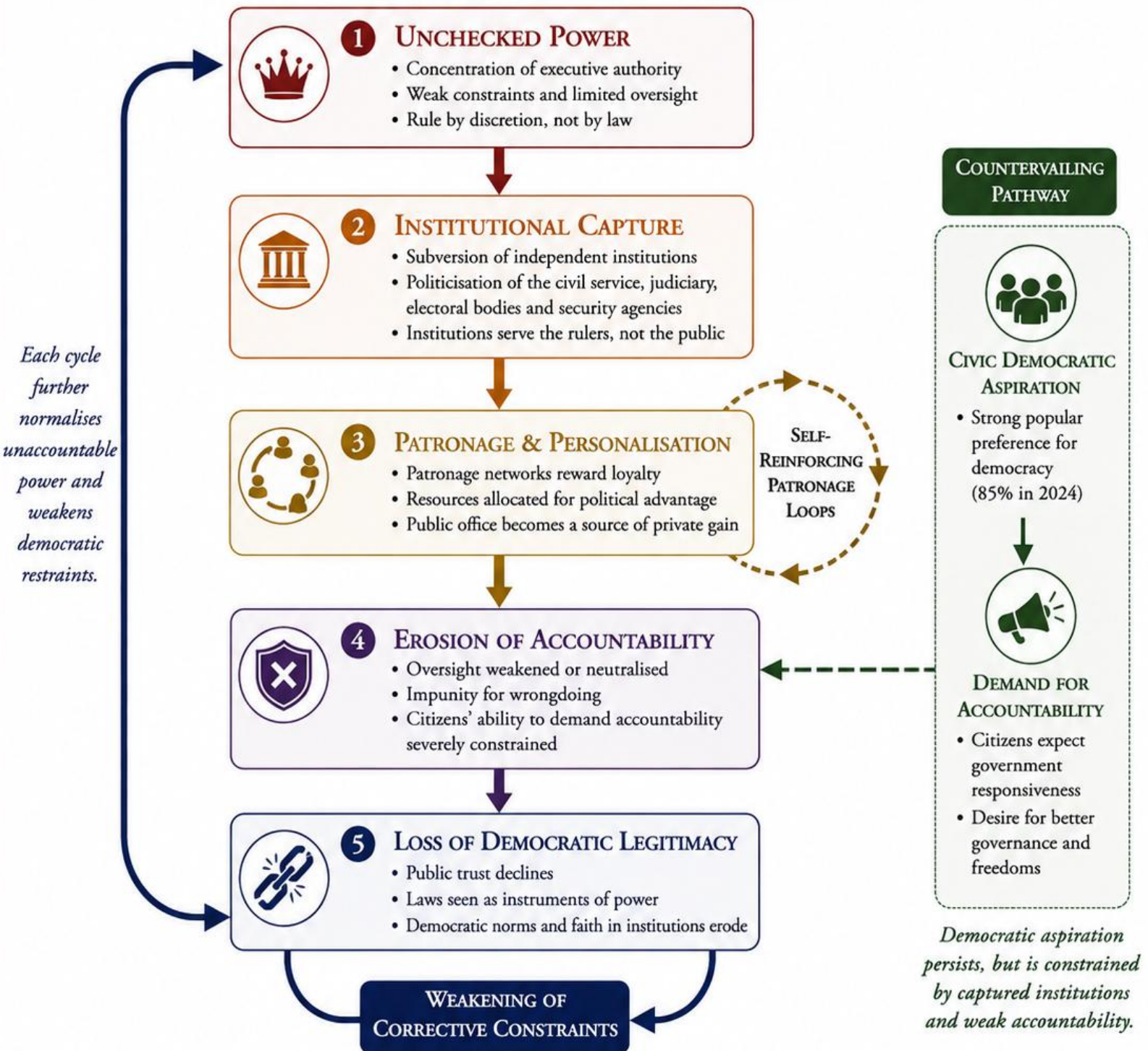
⁴² Freedom House, *Freedom in the World 2026: Zimbabwe* (Washington, DC: Freedom House, 2026). The report assigns Zimbabwe a score of 25/100 and classifies it as “Not Free”; it also describes ZANU-PF's dominance since independence, repression of opposition and critical media, endemic corruption, a vast patronage system, weak rule of law, and consolidation of authority through constitutional amendments.

⁴³ Associated Press, “Zimbabwe’s 83-year-old President Signs Law to Delay Elections and Extend His Own Term,” July 7, 2026. The report states that the amendments were signed into law, postpone the 2028 election to 2030, abolish direct presidential elections in favour of selection by Parliament, and extend presidential and parliamentary terms from five to seven years.

FIGURE 7

The Erosion of Democratic Restraint in Zimbabwe

*A self-reinforcing cycle of power concentration and institutional decay—
despite persistent democratic aspiration*



Interpretive Note: The figure represents a proposed interpretive mechanism rather than a deterministic causal sequence. It illustrates how unchecked power can trigger a self-reinforcing cycle that erodes accountability and democratic legitimacy, even as civic aspiration endures.

Source: Author's synthesis based on Afrobarometer Round 10 (2024), Freedom House Country Reports (Zimbabwe, 2026) and evidence discussed in the Zimbabwe case study.



In DTHF terms, political and economic resources (*Artha*) became increasingly detached from ethical ordering (*Dharma*), as political power became progressively oriented toward its own preservation. The resulting pattern is not simply institutional weakness but a self-reinforcing erosion of corrective constraints: concentration of power facilitates institutional capture; institutional capture weakens accountability; weakened accountability enables further concentration of power.

Yet the erosion of institutional restraint has not eliminated democratic aspiration. Afrobarometer's findings reveal a significant civic counter-current: Zimbabweans continue to prefer democracy while rejecting the principal non-democratic alternatives. Zimbabwe therefore demonstrates that institutional decay does not necessarily imply the destruction of the underlying human aspiration for legitimate and accountable government.

The DTHF significance of the Zimbabwe case lies precisely in this disjunction. The institutions may deteriorate faster than the normative aspirations of the people who inhabit them. Democratic renewal therefore cannot be understood solely as the restoration of institutional mechanisms; it also requires attention to the civic dispositions and expectations that may preserve the possibility of renewal.

XII. What the African Experience Adds to the Dhārmic Theory

1. Restraint must be both internal and institutional

The comparative cases suggest that democratic resilience cannot be explained by external institutional constraints alone. Mandela illustrates the importance of personal restraint; Botswana illustrates its institutionalisation; Ghana illustrates civic demand for character and accountability; Zimbabwe demonstrates the consequences when institutional restraint erodes. The DTHF may therefore be strengthened by distinguishing between the formation of restraint within persons and its embodiment within institutions. Neither can reliably substitute for the other.

2. Capability and restraint are complementary

Rwanda adds an important qualification to the earlier *Good Governance for Growth in Africa* argument. State capability is indispensable to development and order, but capability alone does not establish legitimate political order. Conversely, restraint without sufficient institutional and administrative capability may be unable to deliver security, justice, or material well-being. The deeper proposition is therefore not restraint against capability, but disciplined equilibrium between them.

This refinement is significant for the DTHF because it prevents *Dharma* from being interpreted as restraint in isolation. Legitimate order requires both the capacity to act and the discipline to act within appropriate limits.

The Rwanda counter-case further suggests that flourishing may be substantial in some dimensions while remaining incomplete in others. From a DTHF perspective, such partial flourishing should not be understood simply as failure. It points instead to the possibility of greater integration: capability, order, and material progress may become more comprehensive forms of flourishing when joined to legitimate restraint, plural accountability, and meaningful participation.

3. Relational flourishing is an important dimension of democratic resilience

Mauritius and South Africa suggest that democratic resilience cannot be reduced to vertical relations between citizens and the state. It also depends upon horizontal relations among citizens and communities. Trust, mutual recognition, accommodation, reconciliation, and the capacity to regard political opponents as legitimate participants in a shared order are therefore relevant to institutional durability.

The DTHF's relational order provides a conceptual vocabulary for examining this dimension. It directs attention to a question that institutional analysis can understate: how do political communities sustain relationships of recognition and participation among persons and groups who disagree about power, identity, and the common good?

4. Democratic aspiration can persist despite institutional erosion

Zimbabwe demonstrates that the erosion of democratic institutions does not necessarily eliminate the human aspiration for legitimate government. This distinction suggests that institutional failure and normative failure should not be treated as identical. A population may retain a strong commitment to democratic principles even when its institutions fail to embody them. Human formation and institutional formation are related but not perfectly synchronised.⁴⁴

The persistence of such expectations may itself constitute a reservoir for democratic renewal. Institutional deterioration need not extinguish the normative expectation of accountable and legitimate government. Where citizens continue to regard such government as an appropriate standard against which political authority should be judged, the possibility of institutional recovery remains open.

The distinction is theoretically important because it leaves open the possibility of democratic renewal. Institutional decay need not mean that the underlying aspiration for accountable and legitimate government has disappeared.

5. African experience should refine, not merely receive, DTHF

The relationship between the DTHF and African experience should be dialogical. Concepts such as *Ubuntu*, *Kgotla*, and other endogenous African traditions of relationality, deliberation, obligation, and communal responsibility should therefore be brought into conversation with the DTHF.

Ubuntu is particularly relevant because contemporary African philosophical scholarship understands it in terms of relational personhood: the human person is constituted through relationships with others rather than adequately understood as an isolated individual.⁴⁵ The purpose, however, is not to establish equivalence between *Ubuntu* and the DTHF, but to place distinct intellectual traditions in dialogue, examining their convergences,

⁴⁴ Afrobarometer, *African Insights 2024: Democracy at Risk—The People's Perspective*.

⁴⁵ James Ogude, ed., *Ubuntu and Personhood* (Trenton, NJ: Africa World Press, 2018); Benda Hofmeyr, "Reading Ubuntu Relationality through a Levinasian Lens," *Acta Academica* 57, no. 1 (2025): 53–71.

differences, and respective limits.

The dialogue with *Ubuntu* is especially significant because it brings into view a proposition that resonates with, without being reducible to, the DTHF: individual flourishing cannot be adequately understood apart from the relational and communal orders within which persons become fully human. Such dialogue also helps prevent the DTHF from being presented as a one-way export of Indian categories into African political experience.

Africa thereby becomes not merely a field of application for the DTHF, but a source of conceptual learning through which the theory itself may be tested and refined.

XIII. From Human Formation to Democratic Resilience

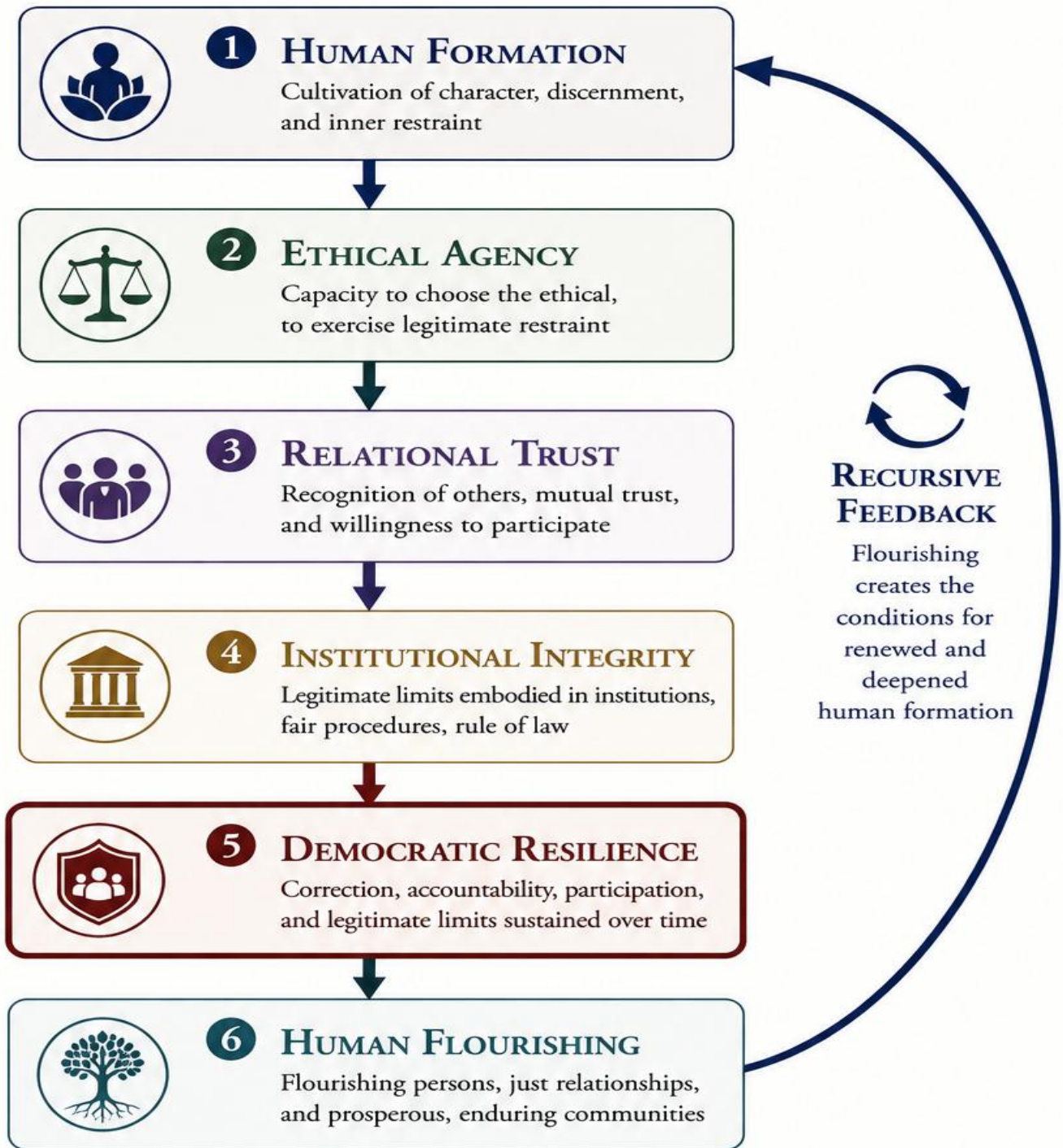
The comparative evidence suggests a recursive rather than linear relationship between human formation and institutional resilience. The six cases illuminate different points within this generative architecture. Mandela illustrates how personal restraint may become ethical agency expressed through public leadership; Botswana shows how such restraint can become institutionalised through peaceful alternation; Ghana demonstrates how civic expectations can shape electoral judgment and political accountability; Mauritius highlights the role of relational accommodation in sustaining plural participation; Rwanda shows the limits of institutional capability when political restraint and plural accountability remain insufficiently developed; and Zimbabwe demonstrates how the erosion of institutional restraint can weaken democratic resilience even while democratic aspiration persists.

Taken together, the cases suggest that human formation may contribute to democratic resilience, while institutional experience in turn shapes the conditions of human flourishing and further formation. The relationship is therefore recursive rather than linear: institutions shape citizens; civic participation can develop habits of responsibility; legitimate institutions can reinforce trust; and flourishing societies can create conditions for renewed human formation.

FIGURE 8

The Recursive Architecture of Democratic Resilience

From human formation to human flourishing—and back again



Note: The arrows indicate a proposed generative and mutually reinforcing relationship, not a deterministic causal sequence. Democratic resilience emerges within a recursive ecology in which institutions shape persons even as persons sustain institutions, and flourishing creates conditions for renewed human formation.

Figure 8 presents the relationship as a proposed generative architecture rather than a deterministic causal sequence. The paper does not claim that human formation mechanically produces democratic resilience. Rather, the quality of human dispositions, relationships, institutions, and civilisational memories may reinforce or weaken one another over time. Different societies may strengthen different links in the architecture, while weaknesses at one point may constrain the functioning of the whole.

The comparative lesson is therefore one of integration rather than linear progression: human capacities, relational patterns, institutional arrangements, and civilisational memories must continually reinforce one another if resilience is to endure.

Democratic resilience may consequently be understood as the capacity of a political community to correct concentrations of power, absorb conflict, renew legitimacy, preserve meaningful participation, and maintain legitimate limits upon authority without destroying the common order. On this understanding, elections are necessary but insufficient. Resilience requires the capacity to accept legitimate limits, tolerate political difference, correct institutional failure, and reproduce these dispositions across generations.

Democratic resilience should therefore not be equated with human flourishing itself. It is better understood as one institutional expression of a wider ecology of flourishing in which ethical, psychological, relational, institutional, and civilisational orders reinforce one another. A political system may exhibit resilience without encompassing every dimension of human flourishing, just as material or administrative achievement may coexist with deficits in political participation, relational trust, or legitimate restraint.

XIV. Democracy and Human Flourishing

The African cases suggest that democratic resilience is best understood not as an isolated institutional achievement, but as one expression of a wider ecology of human flourishing. The comparative evidence indicates that the durability of democratic order depends upon the interaction of capacities that are simultaneously human, relational, institutional, and civilisational.

This perspective also clarifies the significance of the two counter-cases. Rwanda demonstrates that substantial state capability and developmental achievement may coexist with unresolved deficiencies in political restraint and plural accountability. Zimbabwe demonstrates that institutional erosion may coexist with a persistent popular aspiration for democratic government. Both cases therefore caution against treating either institutional performance or democratic aspiration, in isolation, as sufficient evidence of comprehensive flourishing.

The African experience consequently reinforces a central proposition of the DTHF: flourishing cannot be adequately understood through outcomes alone. It concerns the quality of the persons, relationships, institutions, and civilisational practices through which those outcomes are generated and sustained. Democratic resilience matters within this wider architecture because it represents the capacity of a political community to preserve legitimate limits, correct institutional failure, accommodate difference, and renew its common order.

The implication is not that democracy is the final measure of human flourishing, nor that human formation can substitute for institutional design. Rather, democratic institutions and human formation are mutually conditioning. Institutions create environments in which dispositions may be cultivated or weakened; persons and communities, in turn, determine whether institutions are inhabited according to their purposes.

The question for democratic renewal is therefore not merely how institutions can be designed to survive, but how the human and relational capacities required to sustain them can be cultivated and transmitted. This provides the basis for the practical implications that follow.

XV. Implications for Democratic Renewal

The comparative cases suggest that if democratic resilience depends partly upon human formation, democratic renewal cannot be confined to constitutional engineering, electoral reform, or administrative strengthening. Institutional reform remains indispensable, but its

durability may depend partly upon cultivating the persons, relationships, and civic cultures capable of sustaining legitimate institutions.

1. Civic Pedagogy

If democratic resilience requires citizens capable of recognising both rights and responsibilities, civic education must extend beyond procedural knowledge of elections and constitutions. It should cultivate constitutional literacy alongside ethical responsibility, respect for legitimate disagreement, civic participation, and the ability to distinguish political opposition from political enmity.

The objective is not ideological instruction, but the formation of citizens capable of participating responsibly in a constitutional order. In DTHF terms, civic pedagogy is therefore not merely the transmission of information about institutions; it is part of the cultivation of dispositions through which those institutions may be sustained.

2. Leadership Formation

The African cases suggest that the character of political and administrative leadership matters alongside institutional design. Leadership formation should therefore cultivate ethical stewardship, openness to feedback, respect for institutional limits, responsibility for public resources, and willingness to relinquish authority when legitimate succession requires it.

In DTHF terms, the purpose is not to eliminate ambition or political energy, but to order them toward legitimate public ends. Leadership formation consequently becomes a possible means of converting personal restraint into institutional reliability.

3. Cultural and Aesthetic Formation

Democratic resilience also has a cultural dimension. Societies require practices through which citizens encounter histories, identities, suffering, difference, and shared aspirations in forms capable of generating recognition rather than hostility.

Arts, literature, theatre, dance, music, and other cultural practices may contribute to this process by cultivating empathy, shared memory, emotional intelligence, and the capacity to encounter perspectives beyond one's immediate social identity.

Here the DTHF's concept of *Rasa* becomes relevant, not as a decorative addition to civic education, but as a possible aesthetic pedagogy of relational formation.⁴⁶ The proposition requires further empirical examination; the paper does not assume that artistic participation automatically produces democratic virtue. Rather, cultural formation may constitute one of the environments in which the psychological and relational dispositions required for democratic life are cultivated.

These implications do not suggest that human formation can replace institutional reform. Rather, they suggest that institutional reform is more likely to endure when accompanied by the cultivation of the persons, relationships, and civic cultures required to sustain it.

XVI. Conclusion: Beyond the Survival of Democracy

The contemporary African democratic crisis is therefore not adequately understood as a deficit of democratic aspiration alone. The evidence points instead to a persistent gap between democratic aspiration and the institutional capacity to embody it. Constitutional frameworks, electoral procedures, and administrative capabilities remain essential, but their durability depends partly upon the human and relational dispositions that enable institutions to function as intended.

The six cases illuminate different dimensions of this relationship. Mandela illustrates personal restraint at the apex of power; Botswana shows restraint embedded within institutional succession; Ghana demonstrates restraint as a civic expectation; Mauritius illustrates relational accommodation within a plural society; Rwanda demonstrates that capability and developmental achievement do not by themselves resolve the question of legitimate restraint, illustrating how flourishing may remain substantial yet incomplete when capability is insufficiently integrated with political restraint and plural accountability;

⁴⁶ Rohit Viswanath, *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing*, sec. 5, “Bhakti and Rasa: The Relational and Aesthetic Pedagogy of Human Flourishing.”

Zimbabwe shows how institutional erosion can coexist with persistent democratic aspiration, leaving open the possibility of renewal where normative expectations endure.

The African experience therefore suggests that democratic resilience emerges neither from institutions alone nor from individual virtue alone. It arises when ethical orientation, psychological self-restraint, relational trust, institutional integrity, and civic participation reinforce one another across time.

The deeper contribution of *The Dhārmic Theory of Human Flourishing* is consequently not to offer Africa a prefabricated model of governance. It is to propose a different starting point for understanding democratic resilience: institutions are ultimately sustained by human beings whose capacities for restraint, responsibility, relationship, and self-transcendence have themselves been cultivated.

Africa, in turn, adds something to the theory. Its varied democratic experiences demonstrate that capability and restraint, freedom and order, individual aspiration and common good cannot be treated as isolated objectives. Their sustainable relationship requires disciplined equilibrium.

The question beyond democratic survival is therefore not simply how to preserve democratic institutions, but how to cultivate the human beings, relationships, and cultures capable of making legitimate institutions endure.
